

Yulong Zhao

Statistics PhD Candidate | Statistical Machine Learning & Sequential Modeling

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Summary

Statistics PhD candidate building interpretable models for user behavior sequences: time-varying action effects, latent skills and states, and early warning with a controlled false-alarm rate.

Education

University of Arizona — PhD, Statistics	Expected May 2028
University of Wisconsin–Madison — MS, Statistics and Data Science	2023
University of Science and Technology of China — BS, Mathematics and Applied Mathematics	2022

Technical Skills

Programming: Python, R.

Modeling: latent-variable models, EM, regularized GLMs, sequence models (GRU, TCN, Transformer), time-series forecasting.

Tools: NumPy, pandas, scikit-learn, PyTorch, XGBoost, Numba, Git, Slurm/HPC.

Evaluation: cross-validation, bootstrap, walk-forward validation, threshold calibration, multiple-testing correction.

Research Experience

University of Arizona — PhD Researcher 2023 – Present

Advisors: Prof. Xueying Tang, Prof. Hao Helen Zhang | NSF #2310664, #1929348

Time-Varying Action Effects in User Behavior Sequences

- Developed an **interpretable model** that estimates how each action’s effect on task success changes with *when* it occurs, classifying every action as having no effect, a constant effect, or a time-varying effect.
- Applied it to 19,089 events from 2,668 users in an educational problem-solving assessment (OECD PISA 2012), revealing actions whose effect **reverses over task time**, a pattern masked by aggregate action counts.
- Also improved prediction over a count-feature logistic baseline: **50% lower log loss** ($0.237 \rightarrow 0.118$) and accuracy from 93.5% to 96.1% in 10-fold cross-validation, winning every fold.

Early Failure Warning with Guaranteed False-Alarm Control

- Built an **online early-warning system**: a GRU risk model updates each user’s risk of failing after every action and raises an alert **before the user submits**, while there is still time to intervene.
- Designed a **model-agnostic alert rule** calibrated on each user’s peak risk over the whole sequence, with a finite-sample guarantee that the share of successful users ever falsely alerted stays within a chosen budget.
- On OECD PIAAC assessment data, adding users’ behavior on earlier tasks **more than doubled** the share of failing users caught at least 2 actions before submission, **from 14% to 34%** at a 10% false-alarm budget, compared with a published early-window XGBoost baseline.

Learning Latent Skills and Behavioral States

- Developed a **structured latent-variable model** that jointly estimates persistent user skills and evolving behavioral states from interaction sequences, learning sparse skill-to-action mappings without prespecified assignments or labeled states.
- On 1,340 users of an email-and-spreadsheet task, **recovered interpretable structure** without labels: distinct skills for search, sort, and email actions, skills with opposing effects on related actions, and state transitions consistent with the task logic.

Time-Series Forecasting & Regime-Shift Detection

- Built a **PCA + RBF-SVR** pipeline forecasting biological change from paleo-environmental records, with leakage-free walk-forward evaluation; reduced MSE by **38%** on average versus a historical-mean baseline and beat it in all 18 settings.
- Evaluated environmental regime shifts using **recurrence plots**, multiple-testing correction, and preprocessing sensitivity analysis, distinguishing robust findings from preprocessing-dependent results.

Selected Research Outputs

Zhao, Y. & Tang, X. “Scalar-on-Process Model for Educational Assessment: Modeling Time-Varying Action Effects with Group LASSO Regularization.” *Manuscript ready for submission.*

Refereed oral presentation of the above, Symposium on Data Science & Statistics (SDSS), Milwaukee, WI, April 2026.